

INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

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Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

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Contents

Introduction: The Promise and Vulnerability of Independent, Alternative, and Community Media

David W. Park and Meghan Grosse xvii

PART 1: CONCEPTUALIZING INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA

There is No Alternative: The Critical Potential of Alternative Media in the Face of Neoliberalism

Linus Andersson 1

Uncommunicative Partners: Social Movement Media Analysis and Racial Educators

John D. H. Downing 20

Communication and Struggles for Alternatives

Christian Fuchs 29

What We Talk About When We Talk About "Media Independence"

Karl Karpinnen and Hallvard Moe 43

The Unbearable Lightness of Being Alternative: Idealism-Realism and Purism-Pragmatism in Greek Alternative Media

Dimitra L. Milioni and Pantelis Vatikiotis. 59

PART 2: HISTORY, MEMORY, AND ARCHIVES

Hand-Made Memories: Remediating Cultural Memory in DIY Feminist Networks

Red Chidgey 83

Being a Child of the Mines: Youth Magazines and Comics in the Copperbelt

Enid Guene. 93

Social Participation in Indonesian Media and Art: Echoes from the Past, Visions for the Future

Edwin Jurriëns 112

Learning from the History of Alternative Communication Networks

Félix Tréguer, Dominique Trudel, and Mélanie Dulong de Rosnay 134

A Brief History of CCLM/CLMP

Pauline Uchmanowicz 152

<i>Promising Prospects, and the Hurdles Along the Way: Sharing and Archiving Community Media Content Online</i>	
Joost van Beek.	163

PART 3: POLICY, REGULATIONS, AND GOVERNMENT INTERVENTION

<i>Media at the Margins: Policy and Practice in American, Canadian, and British Community Television</i>	
Christopher Ali	173
<i>News by Any Other Name: Community Radio Journalism in India</i>	
Bridget Backhaus	192
<i>'In the Waiting Room': Digitisation and Post-Neoliberalism in Buenos Aires</i>	
Geoff Baker.	208
<i>From Revolution to Reform: Recommendations for Spectrum Policy in Transitional Tunisia</i>	
Moez Chakchouk, Danielle Kehl, Jochai Ben-Avie, and Kate Coyer.	244
<i>From Media Niche to Policy Spotlight: Mapping Community-Media Policy Change in Latin America</i>	
Arne Hintz	269
<i>Community Radio Contradictions in Canada: Learning from Volunteers Impacted by Commercialising Policies and Practices</i>	
Gretchen King and Omme-Salma Rahemtullah	282

PART 4: PRODUCTION AND DISTRIBUTION

<i>Podcasting About Yourself and Challenging Norms: An Investigation of Independent Women Podcasters in Denmark</i>	
Freja Sørine Adler Berg	305
<i>The Business of DIY: Characteristics, Motives and Ideologies of Microindependent Record Labels</i>	
Robin den Drijver and Erik Hitters	323
<i>Intervention for Inclusivity: Gender Politics and Indie Game Development</i>	
Stephanie Fisher and Alison Harvey	342
<i>From Art House to Your House: The Distribution of Quality Cinema on Home Video</i>	
Daniel Herbert	358
<i>SoundCloud and Bandcamp as Alternative Music Platforms</i>	
David Hesmondhalgh, Ellis Jones, and Andreas Rauh.	373

<i>Indie or Mainstream? Tensions and Nuances between the Alternative and the Mainstream in Indie Games</i>	
Ólivier Pérez-Latorre	393
<i>Making Media Together: Experiences of Aboriginal Participation within Co-Creative Remote Media Production Teams</i>	
Laura McDowell.	408
<i>Participatory Film Production as Media Practice</i>	
Antoni Roig Telo	427

PART 5: LABOR, FUNDING, AND PROMOTION

<i>Indie Cinema and Short Film Assemblage</i>	
Thomas Barker	449
<i>Independent Canadian Music in the Streaming Age</i>	
Andrew deWaard, Brian Fauteux, and Brianne Selman	459
<i>Crowdfunding for Independent Print Media: E-Commerce, Marketing, and Business Development</i>	
Peter Konhäusner, Marius Thielmann, Veronica Thielmann, Veronica Câmpian, and Dan-Cristian Dabija	489
<i>'Let's Keep Music Special. F—Spotify': On-Demand Streaming and the Controversy over Artist Royalties</i>	
Lee Marshall	513
<i>DIY or Die? A Typology of DIY Careers in the Portuguese Independent Music Scenes</i>	
Ana Oliveira	528
<i>The Political Economy of Financially Successful Independent Hip-Hop Artists</i>	
Geoff Ostrove.	544
<i>Autonomy, Integration, and the Work of Cultural Intermediation in Indie Games</i>	
Matthew E. Perks, Felan Parker, Jennifer R. Whitson, Gabrielle Lavenir, Ceyda Yolgörmez, Pierson Browne, and Brian Schram	564
<i>Seeking Deep Relations in a Precarious Industry: Addressing Mental Health through Independent Videogame Development</i>	
Paulo Ruffino	584

PART 6: MESSAGES, NARRATIVES, AND REPRESENTATIONS

<i>What I Know Now: Radio as a Means of Empowerment for Women of Lived Prison Experience</i>	
Heather Anderson and Charlotte Bedford.	603

<i>Are You Okay? Mental Health Narratives in Art Zines from the Zineopolis Collection</i>	
Jackie Batey	619
<i>“I Want to Tell You about My Life Now”: The Voice of Palestinian Refugees in Frontiers of Dreams and Fears</i>	
Catherine Burwell	633
<i>American Realities on Public Television: Analysis of the Independent Television Service’s Documentaries, 2007-2016</i>	
Caty Borum Chattoo, Patricia Aufderheide, Michele Alexander, and Chandler Green	647
<i>Against Hollywood: American Independent Film as a Critical Cultural Movement</i>	
Sherry B. Ortner.	670
<i>Alternative Media, Self-Representation and Arab-American Women</i>	
Kenza Oumlil	689

PART 7: AUDIENCES: PARTICIPATION, ENGAGEMENT, AND ACCESS

<i>Conventions, Computers, and Collective Action (1991-2007)</i>	
Francesca Coppa	709
<i>Coming Out as Popular Media Practice: The Politics of Queer Youth Coming Out on YouTube</i>	
Sander De Ridder and Frederik Dhaenens	743
<i>Public Value and Participation of Civil Society—A Case for Public Service or Community Media?</i>	
Manuela Grünangerl, Josef Trappel, and Corinna Wenzel.	759
<i>Moments of Danger: The Struggle for Community-based Public Radio in Baltimore</i>	
Jason Loviglio.	784
<i>Making Media Public: On Revolutionary Street Screenings in Egypt</i>	
Nina Grønlykke Mollerup and Sherief Gaber	800
<i>The Death of Indie Hip-Hop?:The Blurry Lines Between the Majors and Independent Hip-Hop</i>	
Christopher Vito	815

PART 8: JOURNALISM AND THE PUBLIC

<i>Podcasting as Public Media: The Future of U.S. News, Public Affairs, and Educational Podcasts</i> Patricia Aufderheide, David Lieberman, Atika Alkhallouf, and Jiji Majiri Ugboma	841
<i>The Future of Public Service Media and the Internet</i> Alessandra D'Arma, Christian Fuchs, Minna Horowitz, and Klaus Unterberger	861
<i>Community Radio and Peace-building in Kenya</i> Jessica Gustafsson	871
<i>Intersectionality in Autonomous Journalism Practices</i> Sandra Jeppesen and Media Action Research Group	887
<i>Amplifying Counter-Public Spheres on Social Media: News Sharing of Alternative Versus Traditional Media After the 2019 Chilean Uprising</i> Juan Pablo Luna, Sergio Toro, and Sebastián Valenzuelap	906
<i>Iranian Internet Cinema, a Cinema of Embodied Protest: Imperfect, Amateur, Small, Unauthorized, Global</i> Hamid Naficy	926
<i>Media Representations of Burundi's 2020 Elections in Belgium and Burundi</i> Caroline Williamson Sinalo	941
<i>Digital Amplification of Fringe Voices: Alternative Media and Street Politics in Hong Kong</i> Yidong Wang	959

PART 9: COMMUNITY AND LOCALISM

<i>Not Just Surviving but Thriving: Practices That Sustain a New Generation of Latin American Community Media Makers</i> Diana Coryat	983
<i>Community Media Makers and the Mediation of Difference: Claiming Citizenship and Belongingness</i> Lola de Koning, Elaine Nolten, and Koen Leurs	999
<i>Failities at the Borders: Stalled Activist Media Projects in East Africa</i> Christina Dunbar-Hester	1015
<i>Wireless Mesh Networks as Community Hubs: Analysis of Small-Scale Wireless Mesh Networks and Community-Centered Technology Training</i> Jamie Alexander Greig	1035

<i>'Neither Silent Nor Invisible': Anti-poverty Communication in the San Francisco Bay Area</i>	
Dorothy Kidd and Bernadette Barker-Plummer	1063
<i>Core Dimensions of Community Radio in Action: The Case of Ghana</i>	
Lawrence Naaikuur and Africanus L. Diedong	1077
<i>Communicative Sovereignty in Latin America: The Case of Radio Mundo Real</i>	
Katherine Reilly	1096
<i>Combatting Cultural 'Nerve Gas': Maintaining Traditional Media and Culture through Local Media Production in Australia, Canada and Mexico</i>	
Ian Watson	1115

PART 10: NETWORKS AND SOCIAL MEDIA

<i>Activist Networks</i>	
Joshua D. Atkinson.	1133
<i>Why Diverse Zines Matter: A Case Study of the People of Color Zines Project</i>	
Melanie Ramdarshan Bold	1157
<i>FCJ-193 Harboursing Dissent: Greek Independent and Social Media and the Antifascist Movement</i>	
Sky Croeser and Tim Highfield	1172
<i>The Case for Alternative Social Media</i>	
Robert W. Gehl	1189
<i>The Opium of the Paquete: State Censorship, Private Self-Censorship, and the Content-Distribution Strategies of Cuba's Emergent, Independent Digital-Media Start-Ups</i>	
Ted A. Henken.	1209
<i>Bridging the Open Web and APIs: Alternative Social Media Alongside the Corporate Web</i>	
Jack Jamieson, Naomi Yamashita, and Rhonda McEwen	1233
<i>Building Wi-Fi Networks for Communities: Three Canadian Cases</i>	
Catherine Middleton and Barbara Crow	1254

PART 11: ACTIVISM AND RESISTANCE

<i>Punks' Jungle: São Paulo</i>	
Rodrigo Lopes de Barros	1281
<i>The Lumad Struggle for Social and Environmental Justice: Alternative Media in a Socio-Environmental Movement in the Philippines</i>	
Belinda F. Espiritu	1315

<i>Indymedia and the Long Story of Rebellion Against Neoliberal Capitalism</i>	
Natalie Fenton	1332
<i>Bearing Witness to Authoritarianism and Commoning through Video</i>	
<i>Activism and Political Film-Making after the Gezi Protests</i>	
Özge Özdüzen	1339
<i>Alternative Media in Latin American Grassroots Integration: Building</i>	
<i>Networks and New Agendas</i>	
Daniela Parra	1355
<i>Feminist Media as Alternative Media? Theorising Feminist Media from the</i>	
<i>Perspective of Alternative Media Studies</i>	
Jenny Gunnarsson Payne	1374
<i>Media Activism from Above and Below: Lessons From the 1940s American</i>	
<i>Reform Movement</i>	
Victor Pickard.	1390
<i>Queer Blogs and Digital Archives: A Tactical Shift Towards Queer Utopia in Bangladesh</i>	
Mohammed Mizanur Rashid	1405

CHAPTER 3

Communication and Struggles for Alternatives

Christian Fuchs

In Communication and Capitalism: A Critical Theory, 337–
52. University of Westminster Press, 2020.

Abstract

This chapter deals with the question of how communication matters in struggles for a commons-based society. First, the notion of praxis communication is introduced (section 14.1). Second, the chapter discusses the role of alternative media as critical media in social struggles (14.2). Questions of class struggles, communication in class struggles, and struggles for alternative communications deliberately form the conclusion to this book. Given that the many problems outlined in this book result from our capitalist world and capitalist communications, the point is to change the system, which can only be achieved through social struggles. Praxis, class struggles, and social struggles are critical political economy's practical implications.

Praxis Communication

Praxis

How humans react to forms of domination (including exploitation) is not programmed. Some endure violence and oppression because they fear consciously or unconsciously that they may lose something. But resistance can emerge over time or rapidly. Humans neither automatically endure nor automatically always resist domination. Humans' existential fears and needs can be instrumentalised so that they accept domination. Social struggles of

dominated groups always imply risk-taking and uncertainty. When a large enough number of the oppressed take such risks and engage in collective organisation, then resistance to domination comes about. The formation of a collective dimension of consciousness is part of such organisation processes.

In organising politically, humans communicate in order to define goals, identities, and strategies that help them in transformative processes. Political consciousness has the potential to be progressive, but is not automatically progressive. A better society is a possible, but not a certain result of social struggles. Only when objective contradictions trigger the collective political organisation of protests and movements that aim at progressive changes is there a chance for the establishment of a better society.

Critical theory's differentiation between practice and praxis was introduced by Karl Marx. Marx writes in his 'Theses on Feuerbach': '#3 [...] The coincidence of the changing of circumstances and of human activity or self-change can be conceived and rationally understood only as revolutionary praxis. [...] #8 All social life is essentially practical. All mysteries which lead theory to mysticism find their rational solution in human praxis and in the comprehension of this praxis'.¹

For Marx, human beings are practical because they transform society through practices. By praxis, Marx refers to a certain form of practice. Praxis refers to political practices whose goal is a human-centred society. Praxis-oriented humans see such a society as a political need of human beings and try to demystify ideologies that aim at hindering the establishment of such a society. Praxis includes class struggles that aim at abolishing exploitation and domination. Antonio Gramsci argues that the philosophy of praxis critically questions common sense.² Praxis wants to establish an 'absolute humanism'.³ For Gramsci and Marx, praxis is the critical political form of human practice. Praxis is related to socialism and wants to establish a '*free community of free personalities*'.⁴

Marxist humanism combines socialism and humanism. It is based on the insight that critique and praxis 'grasp the root of the matter. But for man the root is man himself', '*man is the highest being for man*'.⁵ Praxis is based on the insight that a good society means a good life for all. Based on this insight Marx articulated the '*categorical imperative to overthrow all relations in which man is a debased, enslaved, forsaken, despicable being*'.⁶

Praxis Communication

For Jean-Paul Sartre, praxis is purposeful human action. He therefore argues that 'language as the practical relation of one man to another is praxis, and praxis is always language'.⁷ This

¹ Karl Marx. 1845. Theses on Feuerbach. In *MECW Volume 5* (pp. 3–5), pp. 3 & 5. In the English translation of the 3rd and 8th Feuerbach-theses, the term 'practice' instead of the term 'praxis' was used. In the quotation I have rendered the term as 'praxis' following Marx's own usage in the German original.

² Antonio Gramsci. 1971. *Selections from the Prison Notebooks*. New York: International Publishers. p. 330.

³ Ibid., p. 417.

⁴ Gajo Petrović. 1967. *Marx in the Mid-Twentieth Century*. Garden City, NY: Anchor. p. 133.

⁵ Karl Marx. 1844. Contribution to the Critique of Hegel's Philosophy of Law. Introduction. In *MECW Volume 3* (pp. 175–187). p. 182.

⁶ Ibid., p. 182.

⁷ Jean-Paul Sartre. 1960/2004. *Critique of Dialectical Reason. Volume One: Theory of Practical Ensembles*. London: Verso. p. 99.

means that, for Sartre, language and communication are always praxis and there is no significant difference between practice and praxis. For Sartre, communication is always already praxis and does not become praxis through socialist politics. In comparison to Marx, Sartre depoliticises the concept of praxis. If all communication were praxis, then the term praxis communication would be tautological. In contrast to Sartre, the approach taken in the book at hand differentiates between practice and praxis and between communication as practice and praxis communication.

Praxis communication is a particular form of human practice that has an ethico-political character. *Praxis communication is always communicative practice*. But only a subset of *communicative practices is praxis communication*. Communication is not automatically good. It is not automatically a means to question domination. Communication is a practice through which humans create and reproduce social relations. They do so by using symbols and interacting symbolically. In communication, humans make meaning of each other's behaviour and utterances. But this mutual referencing does not imply that the participants in a conversation necessarily agree or understand each other. Social struggles and political action can transform communicative practice into praxis communication. Praxis communication takes place within democratic-socialist organisations, groups or structures, or aims at the establishment of such humanist structures. *Praxis communication* is not about society as it is, but about how we can achieve an actual, true society that corresponds to human needs and develops all human potentials so that all benefit.

Activists use communication technologies such as the Internet to challenge exploitation and domination. Alternative online news media such as Democracy Now! or Alternet and digital commons projects such as Wikipedia or Creative Commons question the capitalist character of digital media. Besides such alternative civil society Internet projects there are also potentials for the development of public service Internet platforms. Civil society and public service Internet platforms challenge the corporate Internet giants. They want to create a commons-based, non-commercial, non-profit Internet.

Neither technology nor individual people can radically transform communications so that capitalist communication are transcended and replaced by communication commons. Such a change requires critical individuals who organise politically and engage in class struggles about the character of communications and society. A commons-based society and commons-based technologies can only be achieved by human praxis.

Class struggles in capitalism are a conflict between capital and labour that is expressed in particular practices. It is labour's objective interest to sublimate the conflict between the opposing interests of capital and labour so that a classless society emerges, whereas it is the objective interest of capital to uphold the class conflict. There are mechanisms such as lay-offs, rationalisation, strikes, outsourcing, wage negotiations, etc. that do not sublimate, but mediate the class conflict. The mediation of the class antagonism only temporarily settles the conflict either more in the interest of labour or of capital. But given that the interests of capital and labour are polar opposites, the class conflict cannot be overcome by mediation. In contrast, the sublation (*Aufhebung*) of the class conflict creates a new whole that eliminates class structures, lifts the individuals to a new existence in a class society, and thereby constitutes a qualitative difference.

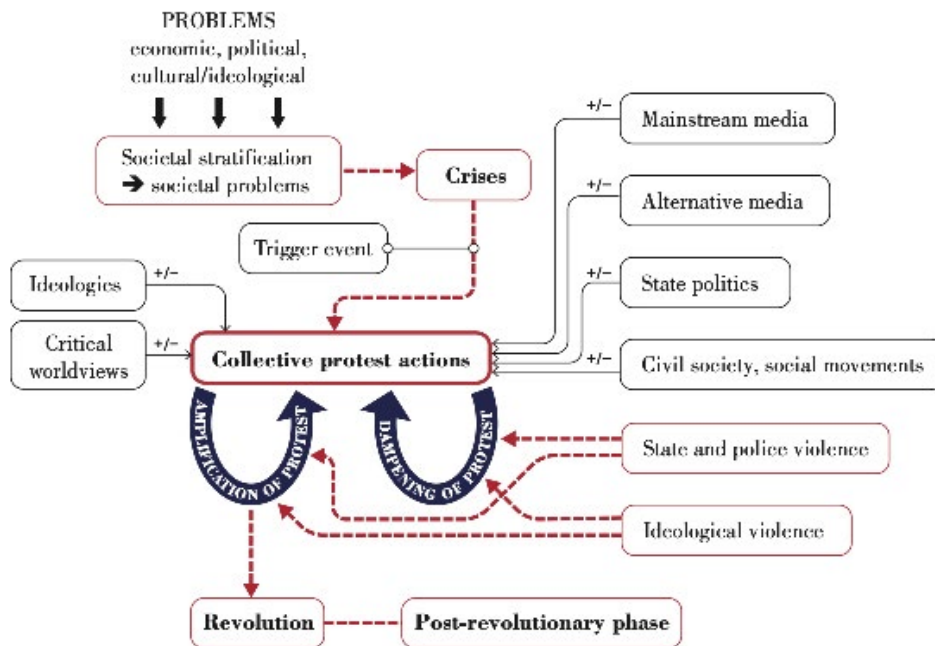


Figure 14.1: A model of praxis communication in social struggles.

Figure 14.1 presents a model that situates the role that communication and communication technologies play in protests and struggles in a broad context.

Protests are based on the structure of society, especially society's economic, political, and cultural contradictions. These contradictions result from particular forms of domination that bring about societal problems. As a consequence, there are phases when societies enter crises. A crisis is a necessary, but not a sufficient condition for the emergence of protests. There are economic, political, and cultural/ideological crises. If such crises interact and converge, then a crisis of society as a whole emerges. For protests to emerge, there must be public recognition of the existence of society's problems, and a significant number of people need to be convinced that these problems can no longer be tolerated and that society needs to be changed. Protests and social movements often emerge from trigger events. Examples are the emergence of the US civil rights movement after the arrest of Rosa Parks, the emergence of the 2011 Tunisian protests after Mohamed Bouazizi's self-immolation following harassment by public officials, the triggering of the 2011 Egyptian revolution by the police's killing of Khaled Mohamed Saeed, or the emergence of the 2013 Gezi protests after police violence against the occupiers of Taksim Square in Istanbul.

It is precisely in such situations that emotions such as anger, class hatred, socialist love, and hope play a role in the potential transition from crises to protests. Subjective perceptions and emotions are, however, not the only factor, because protests are conditioned and influenced by politics, the media and culture/ideology. The way state politics, mainstream media and ideology, on the one hand, and oppositional politics, social movements, alternative media and alternative worldviews, on the other, connect to human subjects, directly influences the conditions of protests. These factors can have rather amplifying, rather neutral,

or rather dampening effects on protests. So, for example, racist media coverage can advance racist stereotypes and/or the insight that the right-wing media and class society are racist in themselves. In an antagonistic society such as capitalism, the means of communication have an antagonistic character. They have antagonistic impacts and effects, which means they can have multiple effects at once and in general either intensify or diminish protest or not have much effect at all on the level of protest.

There can also be antagonisms and power struggles between various media, such as between capitalist media and non-commercial media. But the media is certainly not the only domain of society that shapes protests. There are also other aspects of the economy, politics, and ideology/culture that shape and influence the conditions under which protests emerge and develop, or do not emerge. Multiple dimensions of society influence protests. Given this complexity, it cannot be calculated whether and when protests will develop. When protests emerge, the various factors and dimensions of society continue to have (often contradictory) influences on protests. And protests can also influence other domains of society. To what degree there are positive, negative, or neutral influences is not pre-determined. In antagonistic society, the state, too, often reacts to protests with police action. State violence and ideological violence (e.g. the scapegoating of protesters in tabloid media) directed against protesters influence protests in ways that are not determined. These influences can bring about the intensification or the dampening of protests, or can have no significant consequences at all.

Under certain conditions, protest can intensify in a spiral so that the movements, occupations, and demonstrations become larger and larger. The result can, but does not have to be, a revolution. Revolution means a fundamental change of society so that the economy, politics, and culture are reconstituted and renewed. Revolutions always have post-revolutionary phases in which society needs to be reconstructed. The legacy of old conflicts and the old society can in this context pose challenges.

Communication technology in an antagonistic society, in which the class conflict and other conflicts between dominant and dominated groups matter, is likely to have a contradictory character: It does not necessarily and automatically support/amplify or dampen/limit rebellions, but rather poses contradictory potentials that stand in contradiction with influences of the state, ideology and capitalism.

The next section focuses on alternative media as critical media.

Alternative Media as Critical Media

A Model of Communication

There is a dialectic of structures and practices of communication. They produce each other mutually. The media system is a dynamic system, in which human subjects' communicative practices and communication structures stand in a productive, dialectical, mutually constitutive relationship.

In the media system, we find journalists and other media producers as subjects who make use of particular structures and technologies in order to create content directed at a broad public. They want to shape the consciousness of the members of the public by informing them. Particular media contents have a more or less artistic and aesthetic, news or entertain-

ment character. Created content needs to be organised, stored, and distributed, for which special structures and technologies are needed. Users and audiences receive and interpret distributed content.

The production, distribution, and reception of content are dialectically connected. Without reception, there is no need for further production. Produced content is not effective if it is not received and interpreted. Produced content needs distribution and reception. Reception is not just the consumption of information, but also produces meanings. Reception is consumption and production. Recipients interpret content in the context of their everyday life. What meanings they give to objects depends on their historically conditioned social contexts and experiences. Meanings are social and historical. Under different circumstances, it is likely that an object will be interpreted in different ways. Producers encode certain meanings into content. But there is no guarantee that the recipients will decode the text in the manner intended by the producers. But at the same time, decoding is not arbitrary, because there are

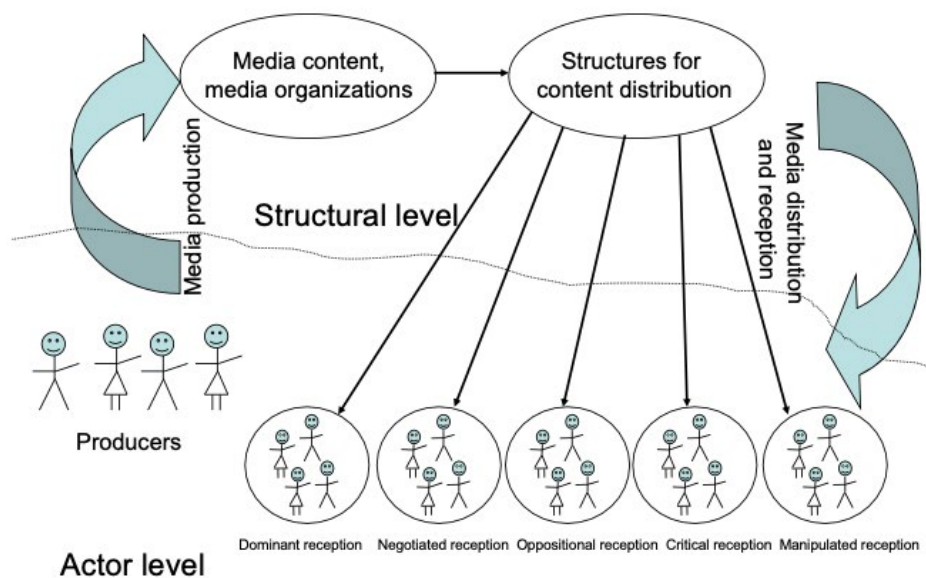


Figure 14.2: The communication process.

power dynamics that influence meaning-making. Different interpretations of content can coexist and contradict each other. There is neither a necessary convergence nor a necessary divergence of encoded and decoded meanings. Power dynamics can result in recipients reproducing hegemonic meanings. There are different forms of reception: hegemony, opposition, mixed meanings, critical reception, and manipulated reception (see chapter 5, section 5.5). There can be overlaps between first three and the latter two types of reception.

Figure 14.2 visualises a model of the communication process.

Media and communication systems are not just social systems, they are social systems that reach a wider public and are therefore part of communication processes in the public sphere. Therefore, the notion of the public sphere is important for a social theory of the media in general (see chapter 8) and therefore also for a social theory of alternative media. For

their operation, media systems and organisations need producers, recipients, organisation structures, distribution structures, and contents. The communication process of the media is based on the dialectic of structures and actors.

For Stuart Hall, there are hegemonic, oppositional, and negotiated (mixed) interpretations of texts.⁸ In order to avoid a relativistic approach, one must assume that there is a degree of objectivity in the communication process. An example: If anti-fascism is the dominant ideology and a message is encoded based on the dominant worldview, then fascism must be characterised as oppositional. Hall's distinction between dominant, oppositional, and negotiated meanings is too restrictive and relativistic. Hence the notion of critical reception/consciousness is added in figure 14.2.

A critical interpretation or meaning is an insight that enables the individual to put domination and exploitation into question and to develop models of society that focus on advancing benefits for all. A co-operative society is the true and essential form of society and human existence. Manipulation tries to advance interpretations that are a form of false consciousness, i.e. that do not put into question exploitation and domination, but rather foster and legitimate class structures and structures of domination in general. Critical and manipulated decoding/interpretation/consciousness are particular forms of consciousness.

The model shown in figure 14.2 has a structural level and an actor level. These two levels interact. Information workers are located on the actor level. They produce content that is publicly communicated. Actors involved in the communication process include journalists, other media workers, and audiences. Media structures include, for example, institutions, products, and technologies used for the production, distribution, and reception of content. Production is the basis for distribution and reception. Distribution and reception in turn are the foundation of further production. In the media system there is a dialectical, dynamic process, where actors and structures interact with each other.

Alternative Media, Critical Media

Alternative media are media that challenge the dominant capitalist forms of media production, media structures, content, distribution, and reception. Table 14.1 is based on figure 14.1. It gives a comparative overview of potential characteristics of alternative media. Not all of these characteristics are necessarily qualities of or conditions for the existence of alternative media. The model shows an ideal-type with a maximum number of characteristics. The central aspects are media producers, recipients, and practices of producers and recipients on the actor level; products, organisations, and distribution structures on the structural level.

In antagonistic societies, we find antagonistic media that at the same time have potentials to advance emancipation and domination. In capitalism, the media always to a certain degree have a repressive character: They sell commodities and distribute ideologies. But the media also have potentials for alternative organisational forms and the distribution of critical content. Such potentials often remain marginal. They do not automatically come into existence, because alternative media face structural inequalities in the capitalist media system. Only social struggles can improve the structural conditions that can help realise such potentials of alternative media. Media and communication are embedded in society's totality and therefore

⁸ Stuart Hall. 1973. *Encoding and Decoding in the Television Discourse*. Birmingham Centre for Contemporary Cultural Studies Stencilled Occasional Papers #5. Birmingham: University of Birmingham.

also within social struggles. We need to decentre the media, which means that technological determinism and a neglect of the influence of society on the media should be avoided.

Alternative media question the capitalist organisation of media production, organisation, content, distribution, reception and structures. Table 14.2 provides a summary of the model outlined in table 14.1. Table 14.3 provides another version, where the dimensions are ordered a bit differently.

Table 14.1: Potential dimensions of traditional and critical media.

Dimension	Capitalist Media	Alternative Media
Media production	Elite media producers: journalists and other media producers as a professional wage-labour class that is confronted with corporate and political pressures, media production is conditioned by power	Citizens' media producers: independence of media production from corporate and political influences and pressures, true journalistic freedom, ordinary citizens as journalists and media producers, citizen-controlled journalism, individuals or groups that are affected by certain problems become journalists/producers or at least the positive subject of reports, journalistic practice as part of protest movement praxis, consumers as producers (prosumers), active audiences
Media product structures	Ideological Form and Content: content is strictly defined by what is considered as popular and sellable. The drive for profit can result in a lack of quality, complexity, and sophistication (as e.g. the case in Yellow Journalism that simplifies reality and is focused on singular examples, emotionalism, and sensationalism). Content takes on an ideological form either by the manipulative reporting of reality or by reporting stories as important that aren't really important for society at large. In any case, such content aims to distract the recipients from confrontation with actual societal problems and their causes.	Critical Form and Content: oppositional content that provides alternatives to dominant perspectives that reflect the rule of capital, patriarchy, racism, sexism, nationalism, etc. Such content expresses oppositional standpoints that question all forms of heteronomy and domination. Forms of counter-information and counter-hegemony include the voices of the excluded, oppressed, dominated, enslaved, estranged, exploited. One goal is to give voices to the voiceless and media power to the powerless, as well as to overcome filtering and censorship of information by corporate information monopolies, state monopolies, or cultural monopolies in public information and communication. There are forms of presentation that are not one-dimensional, but that make demands of the recipients and challenge them in order to advance their imagination and complex, critical thinking (e.g. Brecht's concept of dialectical form in epic theatre, radical discontinuities that shock people).

Dimension	Capitalist Media	Alternative Media
Organisational Media structures	Hierarchical media organisations: organisational media structures: Capitalist media corporations that aim primarily at making profit, financed by selling content to audiences and/or by advertisements. There is private ownership of media corporations and there are hierarchical structures with a clear power differential that creates influential decision-making actors and less influential roles as well as a division of labour within media organisations.	Grassroots media organisations: there is collective ownership and inclusive decision-making by those who work in the organisation, symmetric power distribution and economic self-management. There is a focus on non-commercial, non-profit media that are not financed by advertisements or commodity sale, but by donations, public funding, private resources, or no cost strategies. The division of labour is sublated: the roles of authors, designers, publishers, printers and distributors overlap.
Distribution structures	Marketing and public relations: high-tech distribution, marketing and public relations departments, specialists and strategies, sales departments, advertisements, distribution contracting.	Alternative distribution: technologies that allow easy and cheap reproduction, strategies like anti-copyright, free access (open access), or open content allow content to be freely shared, copied, distributed or changed. Furthermore, there are alternative distributors or alternative institutions (e.g. alternative book stores or libraries) that focus on the distribution of alternative titles.
Reception practices	Manipulated reception: content is interpreted in ways that contribute to false consciousness	Critical reception: content is interpreted in ways that allow the recipients to question domination

Table 14.2: Potential dimensions of traditional and critical media.

Dimension	Capitalist Media	Alternative Media
Media Production	Elite media producers	Citizens' media producers
Media product structures	Ideological form and content	Critical form and content
Organisational media Structures	Hierarchical media organisations, commodity form	Grassroots media organisations with collective ownership
Distribution structures	Marketing and public relations	Alternative distribution
Reception practices	Manipulated reception	Critical reception

Table 14.3: Characteristics of alternative and capitalist media.

		Capitalist media	Ideal alternative media
Media Structure	Economic form of media products	Media product as commodity	Non-commercial media product, non-profit
	Content of media products	Ideological content	Critical content
Media Actors	Consumers	Many consumers	Critical consumers
	Producers	Few producers	Critical producers

In elite media production, there are journalists and other media producers who are wage-workers. They face pressures from corporations and political organisations. Power shapes and influences media production. Professional media workers also have their own professional

ethics and often compete for the accumulation of status. In citizen media, the producers are independent from the power of corporations and political organisations. Everyday citizens can become media producers. Citizens and workers control the media organisations. Those affected by society's problems are present in media reports and content. And they themselves can act as media producers. Alternative media are also often part of social movements. In alternative media, consumers are producers of the media.

Traditional media often produce and disseminate ideology. The published content is mostly shaped by sales perspectives. Commercial media's profit orientation can result in oversimplified, low quality and one-dimensional content. So, for example, tabloid media often simplify reality and use sensationalism. Media content is ideological if it distorts reality or focuses on issues that are presented as important, but distract attention from the focus on problems that are truly relevant for society.

Critical media's content and form are critical. Its content challenges domination, exploitation, capitalism, patriarchy, ideology, racism, sexism, nationalism, etc. Such critical counter-hegemonic information expresses the voices of those who are alienated, exploited, oppressed, enslaved, or excluded. Critical media give voice to the voiceless. They provide communication power for the powerless. They aim at overcoming the censorship and filtering of communication brought about by information monopolies controlled by corporations, the state or cultural organisations. Critical media question one-dimensional forms of presentation. They use forms that enhance complex thought and imagination. An example is Brecht's dialectical, epic theatre.

Capitalist media yield profit by selling access, advertising, content, or technologies as commodities and exploiting communication labour. Such media corporations are privately owned and have a division of responsibilities and labour so that some take all the important decisions and others merely execute labour based on these decisions.

Grassroots media are organisational alternatives to capitalist and hierarchical media. Such organisations are collectively owned; they operate by participatory decision-making, which means that those working in the organisation take collective decisions. Such organisations are forms of economic self-management, where power is more symmetrically distributed. Grassroots media are not-for-profit and often do not sell advertisements or other commodities, but rely on donations, public funding, private resources, low-cost-strategies or no-cost-strategies. There is no rigid division of labour in grassroots organisations; the roles workers have overlap.

Traditional media use marketing, public relations, advertising, branding and high-tech in the process of distribution. Alternative media are open to different strategies, including low-tech and DIY technologies, open access and open content, anti-copyright, free access, etc. There are also alternative distributors that focus on the distribution of critical media. Examples are radical publishers and alternative book stores.

In the reception of information, critical and manipulated reception are two of the ways in which audiences interpret content. Manipulated reception means forms of interpretation that help to create or reproduce false consciousness. In contrast, critical reception means that content is interpreted in ways that make audiences question exploitation and domination. An interpretation of form or content is critical if the audiences are empowered to develop ideas about how to foster a co-operative society.

The models shown in tables 14.1, 14.2, and 14.3 describe ideal-type alternative media. Under ideal conditions, all of the dimensions of alternative media can be realised, including self-managed organisations, and widely available and widely consumed critical content that is critically interpreted and brings about change in society, including animating citizens to become alternative media producers. Ideal-type alternative media work best under conditions that provide citizens with the resources, time, and skills needed for them to participate in the public sphere. If critical media flourish under such conditions, then the division between media production and media consumption disappears. Grassroots media then become the standard form of media. Such conditions cannot be created within a capitalist society, but rather require the creation of a society of co-operation and the commons that is governed in the form of a participatory democracy.

Prefigurative politics assumes that alternatives to capitalism can already be established within capitalism. Prefigurative politics also believes that within a capitalist framework, alternatives can operate relatively autonomously from capitalist structures. Alternative media, however, often face the problem of resource precarity and voluntary, self-exploitative, precarious labour. This type of media should therefore not be idealised. Self-managed organisations are not always politically progressive. It is perfectly possible for self-managed media to advance fascist or other repressive contents. A communication system must at least have critical content or critical form in order to be an alternative medium. In cases where audiences critically interpret repressive content published in traditional media, one cannot speak of alternative media, only of alternative reception. Certain parts of mainstream media can at times have critical content. The minimum condition for defining a medium as critical is that it is a critical product. But of course, it is desirable that as many dimensions of alternative media as possible can be realised. In capitalism, it is, however, difficult to reach all of these desirable aspects of alternative media. If one rigidly focuses on all dimensions, then one assumes that an alternative society can already be created within capitalism without abolishing structures of exploitation and inequalities. Citizen journalism, self-managed organisation, alternative distribution channels, and critical reception practices are desirable, but not necessary, features of alternative media. Critical content and critical form (= *critical media products*) constitute alternative media's necessary features. Alternative media are critical media.

Types of Critical Media

By using the method of advancing from the abstract to the concrete, we can identify subtypes of critical media. We will now introduce a typology that presents different forms of critical media (see table 14.4). The typology is based on the following questions: (1) what parts of the body are predominantly used in media production and reception; (2) is communication synchronous or asynchronous; (3) does communication take place spatially over a distance, or in the presence of the other communicators.

Table 14.4: A typology of alternative media.

Communi- cation	Produc- tion	Recep- tion	Formats	Time	Space	Alternative Media	Examples
Print/visual communi- cation	Brain, hands	Brain, eyes	Newspaper, journal, books, pamphlets, leaflet, comics, sa- tirical prints, flyers, visual art, graffiti, dress, textiles, pins, buttons, stickers, murals, etc,	Asyn- chronous	Dis- tance	Alternative press, critical art	Jacobin, Mother Jones, Oz, Bay Guardian, The Nation, Le Monde Di- plomatique, New States- man, Fifth Estate, Class War; Duane Hanson, Joseph Beuys
Audio com- munication	Brain, mouth	Brain, ears	Radio, telephone	Synchro- nous	Dis- tance	Free radio, independ- ent radio, com- munity radio, pirate radio	Pacifica Radio Network, KPFA Berkeley, KPFK Los Angeles, KPFT Houston, WBAI New York, WPFW Washing- ton DC, National Fed- eration of Community Broadcasters, Grassroots Radio Coalition
Audio com- munication	Brain, mouth, body	Brain, ears	Face-to-face communication, Conversation, talks, lectures, singing songs	Synchro- nous	Pres- ence	Radical sing- ing, protest singing	'Oh, freedom' (abolition- ism), 'We Shall Over- come',
Audio com- munication	Brain, mouth, body	Brain, ears, body	Concerts, choir, dancing	Synchro- nous	Pres- ence	Alterna- tive music concerts, protest song concerts	Alternative music, re- corded protest songs
Audio com- munication	Brain, mouth, body	Brain, ears, body	Sound recordings (records, music cassettes, CD, MP3, etc)	Asyn- chronous	Dis- tance	Alterna- tive music, recorded protest songs	Mogwai, Godspeed You! Black Emperor, Billy Bragg, Robert Wyatt, 'The Preacher and the Slave' (Joe Hill, social- ist), 'Bombtrack' (Rage against the Machine, social justice), 'Sound of Da Police' (KRS- One, anti-racism), 'Kill the Poor' (Dead Kennedys)
Audio- visual com- munication	Brain, mouth, body	Brain, eyes, ears	Theatre, perfor- mance, happening	Synchro- nous	Pres- ence	Critical theatre	Youth International Theatre (guerrilla- theatre), Brecht's epic theatre

Communi- cation	Produc- tion	Recep- tion	Formats	Time	Space	Alternative Media	Examples
Audio- visual com- munication	Brain, mouth, body	Brain, eyes, ears	Film, video	Asyn- chronous	Dis- tance	Critical television, independ- ent cinema, underground film, avant- garde film, amateur videos	<i>Democracy Now!</i> , <i>Crash</i> (Paul Haggis, 2004); films by Jean-Luc Godard, Rainer Werner Fassbinder, Andy Warhol
Audio- visual com- munication	Brain, mouth, body	Brain, eyes, ears	Live television	Synchro- nous	Dis- tance	Public access television	Manhattan Neighbor- hood Network
Multi- media, computer, Internet communi- cation	Brain, hands, mouth, body	Brain, eyes, ears	Digital text, digital audio, digital video, real time text/ audio/ video chat, online radio, online TV, wikis, blogs, Internet art, etc	Synchro- nous or asyn- chro- nous	Dis- tance	Alternative online media	Novara Media, Young Turks, The Canary, Another Angry Voice, Indymedia, Altnet

Given that critical form and critical content are decisive for the alternative character of the media, one cannot argue that all community-produced, non-commercial, 'free', independent, self-managed, self-organised, etc. media are alternative, although many of them are because they feature critical content. They are more likely to be critical than conventional media, but they are not automatically critical.

The key feature on which the typology is built is the notion of critical products that have critical content and critical form. Alternative media, like critical media, are critical products, which means that they have critical form and/or critical content. There can be critical form without critical content and vice versa. Critical form and critical content can also occur together. In artworks such as films, music, concerts, literature, theatre, visual arts or digital arts, form is of particular relevance. Art exists through its aesthetic appearance. It is critical if it is non-identical with society and strengthens imagination. Its content is therefore not directly critical. Art's critique lives through its form and art's non-identity with society. But there is of course also critical political art that not only works at the level of form, but also at the level of content that is directly critical of domination and exploitation.

Summary and Conclusions

We can summarise this chapter's main conclusions:

- There is no pre-defined role of communication technologies in social struggles. Because capitalism is an antagonistic society, communication technologies often have an antagonistic role in this society.

- There are potentials for alternative media as critical media to challenge the capitalist organisation of the communication system. Providing access to critical forms and critical content is one of the foundations for critical debate, critical engagement, and critical consciousness.
- Critical media and the use of communications as tools of emancipatory struggles are forms of praxis communication.
- Alternative media face certain structural limits in capitalist society. The history of alternative media is a history of resource precarity and voluntary, self-exploitative labour. Alternative media therefore need to be complemented by public service media as alternatives to capitalist media. Alternative media require public sources of funding in order to be able to constitute a strong counter-public sphere.
- In capitalism, the class struggle is not only between capital and labour, but in the realm of communication also between capitalist media on the one side and commons-based, alternative, critical, and public media on the other side.
- Strengthening critical media must be part of any progressive political agenda.

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